

LONGSHIP strong, swift vessels used by the Norse to explore, raid and trade – sometimes called “dragon-ships”

MEGINGJÖRD Thor’s magical belt, which doubled his already great physical strength

MIDGARD one of the nine realms – land of human mortals

MJÖLNIR Thor’s magical hammer, which always hits its target and afterwards returns to his hand

MUNIN “memory” – one of Odin’s two spying ravens

MUSPELHEIM one of the nine realms – the smoke-filled home of the Fire Giants

MYTHOLOGY collection of stories created by a particular culture, often involving lessons about life and morality

NIFLHEIM one of the nine realms – the cold, icy, mist-shrouded realm of the dead

NINE WORLDS lands of Norse mythology: Alfheim, Asgard, Nidavellir, Jotunheim, Midgard, Muspelheim, Niflheim, Svartalfheim and Vanaheim

OLD NORSE ancient language spoken by the Norse

PANTHEON group of related gods and goddesses, such as the Vanir and Aesir

RAGNARÖK the final and inevitable end of the Norse gods and goddesses

REBIRTH process of returning from death to start a new life

REVENGE desire to punish or cause pain to someone you believe has done you wrong

RING FORT village surrounded by a ditch and wooden wall to protect it from enemy attack

RUNES letters in the Old Norse language carved onto wood, metal or stone

SAEHRIMNIR boar that is killed every night for food in Valhalla and then reborn the next day

SEIDR Norse word for “magic” – the Vanir goddess Freya taught it to the Aesir

SHAPESHIFTER someone with the ability to change into animal form – Odin, Loki and Freya could shapeshift

SKALD writer of poetry about the extraordinary deeds of Viking leaders

SKIDBLADNIR the best of all ships; it could be folded up and put into one’s pocket

SLEIPNIR “slipper” – Odin’s eight-legged horse

SPITTLE saliva; Kvasir, wisest of all, was born from the spittle of the Aesir and Vanir

SVARTALFHEIM one of the nine realms – home of the dwarfs and the dark elves

THRYMHEIM “thunder home” – beloved mountain abode of the giantess Skadi

TRICKSTER mischievous character who likes to sow chaos and confusion – Loki is a trickster

TROLL mythical creature that can be monstrous or beautiful

UTANGARD “outside the enclosure” – uncivilized and in a state of disorder and chaos; the opposite of “innangard”

VALHALLA Odin’s giant drinking hall, where the souls of brave warriors go after death

VALKYRIES powerful spirits taking the form of flying warrior women – they carry souls to Valhalla

VANAHEIM one of the nine realms and land of the Vanir gods and goddesses

VANIR one of the two tribes of Norse gods and goddesses – particularly associated with wisdom, magic and fertility

VIGRID “place on which battle surges” – location of battle between the gods and giants during Ragnarök

VIKING another name for the Norse; it means “raider”

WHETSTONE tool used to sharpen blades – sometimes used by giants as weapons

YGGDRASIL also called the World Tree, this is the magical tree at the centre of the cosmos – all nine realms can be found in its branches and roots